

# China and the Global Order: Reform, Revisionism and Strategic Intent

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## Is China Committed to Upholding the Current Global Order or is it a Revisionist Power?

Increasingly referred to as a revisionist power, China's foreign policy ambitions are a major cause of anxiety in the West. The United States (US) 2022 National Security Strategy specified "authoritarian governance with revisionist foreign policy" as their "most pressing strategic challenge"; labelling China as "the only competitor with both the intent to reshape the international order and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to advance that objective" (The White House 2022, 8). However, Chinese foreign policy does not resemble that of a traditional revisionist power. In application to reality, the dichotomisation of states into revisionist and status-quo categories becomes highly problematic. The global order is not a fixed and explicit entity, but rather a flexible, evolving and abstruse mesh of institutions, rules, principles and practices. In this regard, a state's relationship with the order resembles a spectrum rather than a binary exclusive: a state can accept some aspects of the global order, whilst remaining in contention with others. Many states that are widely considered status-quo still challenge certain international rules and norms. Indeed, by most measures, the US is more revisionist than China (Chan et al. 2018). This essay will challenge a large body of the literature to assert that China is not simply a traditional revisionist power, but rather a neo-revisionist power: China wishes to "deliberalise" the global order, but not uproot or abandon it. The classification of China as purely revisionist is an unhelpful and dangerous simplification that skews understanding. Rather, a closer and more detailed reading of China's foreign policy is required. In line with this argument, after attempting to define the current global order, this essay will explore China's nonconformist strategy. Subsequently, this will be contrasted to the aspects of the global order that China accepts and defends. Adopting a liberal framework, the essay will build on the works of John G. Ikenberry, introducing a more precise and pointed term to summarise China's foreign policy: neo-revisionism.

While scholars generally accept that contemporary states exist within a global order that shapes their intentions and actions, the nature of the order remains ambiguous. Citing Joseph S. Nye Jr., Hans Maull says that a functioning international order is "like oxygen in the air: you do not take notice of it until it begins to disappear" (2018, 1). At its most basic, order implies structure, pattern or restraint – an antonym to chaos or anarchy. Ikenberry defines an international order as a "set of governing arrangements between states, including its fundamental rules, principles, and institutions" (2001, 23).

While states, regimes and institutions may be constitutive of an international order, they are not synonymous with it. Despite this, realist models often conflate the two. E. H. Carr (2001), for example, argues that international institutions are merely instruments of the dominant actors to further entrench their power over the international system. Accordingly, Carr asserts that “thought follows purpose”: liberalist thought is a smokescreen that serves the self-interest and self-righteousness of powerful states (2001, 62). The neo-realist school built on this notion, arguing that the international system is merely regimented by its “polarity” – the distribution of power across states (Waltz, 1979). This understanding has caused a large body of the literature to muddle international order with the structure of power and to “assume that [the] order and the interests of the hegemon or dominant state are mutually constitutive” (Johnston 2019, 12). This tendency not only implies that the hegemon can never act in a manner inconsistent with the order, but also considers any attempt by another state to improve its international standing as a challenge to the order and inherently revisionist (Chan et al. 2021, 5). Power-transition theorists fall into a similar trap, positing a near-symbiotic relationship between the rise and fall of orders and the rise and fall of hegemonic powers (Organski and Kugler 1980). The theory claims that major wars are caused by the overtaking of the dominant hegemon by a rising revisionist power, typified by Thucydides’ Athens and their inescapable war with Sparta. This notion has fuelled fearful speculation that the US and China will “stumble to war” (Allison 2017). However, such theories discredit any independence of the international order from the hegemon, ignoring the continuities that have evolved across hegemonic powers. As Ikenberry states, the “international order is not simply an artifact of concentrations of power. The rules and institutions that make up international order have a more complex and contingent relationship with the rise and fall of state power” (2018, 20).

Indeed, the international order’s nature is a complex and multifaceted aggregation, not a distinct hegemonic construction: it is more of a “messy, contested and often contradictory bundle of purported rules and expectations” than a “clean and clear-cut set of principles that can be applied in an objective fashion by world leaders” (Harris, 2015). The current global order contains the fundamental practice and norms of state sovereignty, governing institutions such as the United Nations (UN), and a sprawling assortment of regimes, treaties, alliances, agreements, protocols, and so forth (Ikenberry 2018, 20). Furthermore, the international order is constantly in flux, being contested and renegotiated (Buzan 2018). It is not, therefore, a stable settlement that states can binarily choose to join or challenge.

It follows that the dichotomy of revisionism versus status-quoism is dubious. With a wealth of diverse understandings and interpretations of the international order's overlapping and sometimes contradictory rules, norms and principles, revisionism becomes unclear and subjective. Chan et al. argue that "support or rejection of international order is never a matter of all or nothing...the current literature grossly oversimplifies matters" (2021, 12). Instead, states choose to adopt and recognise certain features of the order, whilst simultaneously contesting or renegotiating others. In this sense, "the international order offers a buffet of options and choices" (Ikenberry 2018, 21). It is clear that the rejection or abandonment of a singular aspect of the order does not always qualify a state as revisionist: historically, nearly all states have rejected, contested, or broken a rule or two of the order, yet not all states are considered revisionist.

The current international liberal order (ILO) is underwritten by liberal ideological principles, such as democracy, freedom, human rights, openness, and interdependence. In line with liberal theories of peace – institutionalism, economic independence theory, and democratic peace theory – such values appeal to a sustainable international order that advances peace across the world (Mearsheimer 2019, 23). The end of the Cold War allowed the order to flourish and spread outward alongside globalisation. The order appeared to offer "a universal logic for global politics" (Ikenberry 2018, 17), alluring liberal gurus into a conviction that the world had reached "the end of history" (Fukuyama 1989). Such universalist rationale is still evident in the rhetoric of Western statesmen: as US president Joe Biden recently proclaimed, "freedom. There is no sweeter word than freedom. There is no nobler goal than freedom. There is no higher aspiration than freedom" (2023). Eamon Fingleton writes, "almost without exception, American opinion leaders hold as a matter of high ideology that Western logic is universal and thus is destined to sweep the world" (2008, 4).

The institutions and norms of the ILO have become deeply embedded with liberalism. For instance, the UN labels democracy as a "global issue" and proudly claims: "in the 75 years since the UN Charter was signed, the UN has done more to support democracy around the world than any other organization" (UN 2023a). Likewise, International Monetary Fund (IMF) financing is provided on the conditionality of demonstratable policy actions, such as improving transparency and reforming state-owned enterprises (IMF 2023). To Western policymakers, the protection of fundamental liberal values often takes precedence over other rules and aspects, which are occasionally eschewed in liberalism's defence. "The world has a clear

interest in the spread of democratic values,” US President George W. Bush declared during his justification for the *illegal* 2003 Iraq invasion: “stable and free nations do not breed the ideologies of murder. They encourage the peaceful pursuit of a better life” (2003). The internal paradox in such a statement, that a murderous ideological war is justified to prevent “ideologies of murder”, fuelled criticism of the US-led ILO. Nevertheless, Western states considered “the defence of values of nationhood, particularly liberty and democracy, to require pro-activism” (King 2006, 164); a pro-activism that is at times contradictory to other rules and norms. The Responsibility to Protect (R2P) norm asserts that state sovereignty is not just protection from outside interference, but rather pertains to a responsibility: states have responsibilities for their population’s welfare and the international community has a “residual responsibility” to ensure this is honoured (UN 2023b). R2P was unanimously adopted at the 2005 UN World Summit, the largest gathering of Heads of State and Government in history. However, the agreement for R2P was largely based on a diluted version which “merely papered over divisions” (Kurht 2022, 139), showing that some actors never fully supported the concept.

As an authoritarian state, China does not consider liberal values indispensable to the ILO. China is incentivised to defend the aspects of the order that protect Chinese interests, like sustained economic growth, improved international recognition (Murray 2019), and most fundamentally, the conservation of the Chinese Communist Party’s monopoly on domestic political power (Owen 2021, 1417). The ILO is deemed incompatible with this trinity of aspirations due to its bias against authoritarianism and illiberal practice. With the relative weakening of US hegemony, China wishes to delete this bias from the ILO. Chinese President Xi Jinping is determined to “take an active part in leading the reform of the global governance system” (Xinhua 2018) and has framed his vision for a new global order as “a community of common destiny” (Rolland 2020, 36) – “a shared future for mankind” (Hrubec 2020, 294). The inclusivity of this rhetoric tells of China’s non-prejudice to regime type. In accommodating authoritarianism, China will make the international environment safer to its own model and alleviate its anxieties for survival (Owen 2021).

China’s methods to achieve this goal are centred on the integration of foreign economies with their own. The principal tool, what Nadège Rolland (2020) labels “the new order’s backbone” (40), is the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) – a one trillion US\$ infrastructure-building project that sweeps across Asia, East Africa, the Middle East, Europe, Latin America, and the Arctic (Rolland 2020, 41). More than just an economic trade and growth engine, John M. Owen

describes how the BRI will “make host countries dependant on China – through indebtedness, trans-shipment and imports” – which in turn will make “those host countries less beholden to the wealthy democracies, thereby reducing pressure on China to democratise its political system” (2021, 1427). On the surface, the BRI seems aggressively neo-mercantilist and illiberal. Instead of employing locally, Chinese workers are often sent abroad to complete development projects (Spatafora 2019). And while China asserts that the BRI is open to participation from investors from all countries, “lack of transparency in bidding and procurement procedures means” European companies “are often not even allowed to bid for contracts” (Mohan 2018, 3).

China’s neo-revisionist playbook also includes novel institutions and norms. Sun Jisheng explains China’s adoption of a two-pronged strategy to institutional power: the first prong is the reformation of existing institutions to “increase the institutional discourse power of developing countries represented by China” to “break the monopoly position of developed countries” (Sun quoted in Rolland 2020, 45). An example of such leverage is China’s increase in voting shares in the IMF and World Bank, as well as China’s improved ability to “block actions and take the initiative.” The second prong refers to the creation of new institutions that China can influence from the beginning, such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the Silk Road Fund and the New Development Bank. An example of this influence in action is China’s handling of human rights norms. Snubbing the ILO’s advocacy of universal human rights, China is pushing to make human rights relative to regional and historical contexts, wherein “the state is the final arbiter” (Hart 2020, 2). Unlike the Western institutions of the IMF and World Bank, which use financial leverage to liberalise, the AIIB lacks conditionality on the human rights records, democracy or transparency of borrowers (Owen 2019, 59).

If the BRI is the backbone of the new order, Rolland calls institutional power its “tendons” (2020, 44). Rolland also identifies China’s proposed model of global networks and partnerships as the new order’s “sinews” (41). One could suggest numerous additional biological metaphors for China’s neo-revisionism – for instance, blood vessels for the spreading of narratives, information systems, and academic influence (Edel and Shullman 2021). Soon there would be an entire anatomical model of China’s world order. The question is, how similar is this model to the ILO? Which fundamental organs have been replaced, if any? The conventional Western assumption is that China’s ultimate aim is to disassemble the existing architecture of the ILO

and globalise the forceful, hegemonic stance that it has recently asserted regionally in the South China Sea (Rabbani 2019). However, China has developed and thrived in the ILO. China's vision of a "deliberalised" order still contains many of the institutions, norms and rules of the ILO, including a commitment to the UN and other governing international bodies and laws, as well as the principles of economic openness, globalisation and interdependence. Fu Ying, the chairperson of the Chinese National People's Congress Foreign Affairs Committee, declared that China "has a strong sense of belonging" to the "UN and its institutions, including the principles of international law" but rejects "Pax Americana" and the dominance of Western values (2016, 3). Furthermore, while the BRI and AIIB contain some illiberal dynamics, they are both ultimately founded on the free market principles of globalisation, foreign investment, market development and international cooperation. Indeed, AIIB members include numerous states considered liberal and status-quo, including Australia, Germany, France, South Korea, Netherlands, and the United Kingdom, to name a few.

Even if China did wish to undermine and replace the existing order, Ikenberry highlights that the constraints to doing so are tremendously overwhelming (2018, 27). Firstly, to build an order that reproduced an illiberal model of political and economic organisation, China would require consent from stakeholders. In the ILO this consent rested on transparency and the potential for shared growth and advancement (Ikenberry 2018, 25). Without transparency, China's illiberal order can only offer either material benefits or coercion, the latter entailing a near-endless expense of resources. Secondly, China's economic rise and consequent political power are fuelled by liberal trade. A deglobalised world populated by isolated, competing orders would cut off China from markets and investment opportunities (Ikenberry 2018, 27). At the 2017 World Economic Forum in Davos, President Xi issued a speech in strong defence of economic globalisation: "the global economy is the big ocean you cannot escape from", China had "learned how to swim" (World Economic Forum 2017). China does not wish to revolutionise the world order or replace it with a radical alternative. Instead, China wishes to use the mechanisms and processes embedded within the ILO to set their agenda; a deliberalisation from the inside.

To conclude, there is no accuracy in painting China with the same brush as previous rising revisionist powers, instead, China's ambitions are more akin to a neo-revisionism. The ILO resembles a highly complex and multifaceted entity that has become more independent from its hegemonic creator than previous orders. Underwritten by liberal principles, rules and norms,

the global order contradicts China's authoritarian model of government. Therefore, via novel institutions and soft power, China aims to remove such a prejudice, whilst remaining committed to other fundamental aspects of the order. Thus, there is at least the potential for China and the US to both remain jigsaw pieces in the puzzle that is global order.

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